Why online platforms persist and why players stay

Mario Kart MMORPG evidence and durable access for Blackwish

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A committed community can help an online world survive, but people staying is not the same as a service remaining usable, and neither fact alone explains why its operator keeps paying for it. Long-lived platforms combine reasons to return with a workable way to maintain the experience. Some also impose substantial costs on leaving. These mechanisms need to be distinguished rather than gathered under a single retention number.

The remembered Mario Kart story involved player-operated automation, not documented Nintendo AI to retain customers. Its significance depends on distinguishing a surviving session from a usable service. [2]

MMORPGs provide a richer comparison because they combine persistent characters, repeated play, relationships, shared economies and continuing operating costs. Their histories can illuminate durable value, network effects, return after absence, maintenance and closure. They cannot establish that every loyal audience prevents shutdown, or that an old account has been continuously active.

For Blackwish, the useful objective is **durable access to worthwhile work and voluntary reasons to return**, not keeping a person connected for its own sake. This reference links the platform evidence to the earlier distinction between preserving a promised benefit and freezing its original delivery method. It proposes no live service, bot deployment, human experiment or revision. The project baseline remains the supplied free, offline-first, G-rated PREVIEW v7.1; those are project descriptions, not new findings or external certification. This research has not been manually ratified.

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1 What happened in Mario Kart

The shutdown and the surviving session

Nintendo's official notice discontinued most Nintendo 3DS and Wii U online play and associated communication functions on 8 April 2024 at 5 p.m. Pacific daylight time, or 9 April at 00:00 UTC. That was an online-service closure, separate from the earlier end of eShop purchasing. [1]

The two-player holdout associated with the AI story was **Mario Kart 7 on Nintendo 3DS**, not Mario Kart 8 on Wii U. Contemporary reporting reproduced participant fishguy6564's account of two automated racers and a patch intended to prevent disconnection. On 13 May, marioiscool246's console reportedly froze after 13,151 races, leaving the other client behind. These are participant and community reports, not an inspected Nintendo server trace. [2]

In an August interview, fishguy6564 explained that the patch left his client treating its departed peer as connected and awaiting a response. That establishes neither completed multiplayer races nor fresh access, and does not identify which central server processes remained necessary. [3]

The community tracker dates the remaining console's crash to 3 November 2024 in US Eastern time, corresponding to 4 November UTC. Contemporary reporting reproduced the participant's final post. Reports differ between 209 and 210 days; about seven months avoids false precision. This was the last **known** holdout, not a Nintendo-certified census. [4] [5]

What the story does and does not demonstrate

The reported bots automated racing; the patch addressed session termination. AI is sometimes used broadly for game bots; the specific controller was not established here. No retrieved evidence identifies a learned model or Nintendo-directed retention campaign. [2]

A useful test of any similar story is to ask four separate questions: Can an existing client remain connected? Can participants still complete the activity? Can a new person join? Who is maintaining the service, under what commitment? A screenshot or long-running session might answer only the first.

Replacement networks answer a different question. Pretendo describes an open-source Nintendo Network replacement using custom servers and separate accounts. That is reconstruction and migration, not continuity of Nintendo's original service. It may preserve an activity without preserving the same operator, identity system or entitlement. [6]

2 What staying and staying online actually mean

People do not have only two states

A person can keep an account while playing elsewhere, take a long break and return, renew a subscription without playing that week, or play on several platforms simultaneously. These are different from uninterrupted use. The research question should therefore specify the behavior of interest rather than treating emigration as a single irreversible event.

Retention usually asks whether a defined cohort returns or remains active within a stated period. **Renewal** concerns continued payment or entitlement. **Tenure** measures elapsed time from a starting point, not continuous participation. **Concurrency** counts simultaneous activity or connections at a moment. **Migration** concerns movement of activity, relationships or data. **Multihoming** means using more than one service. A case can show one of these without demonstrating the others.

For example, a ten-year-old account that returns for a new expansion is evidence of a durable relationship and reactivation. It is not evidence that its owner never left, played every month, or avoided competing games. A community can also migrate its conversation while continuing to meet inside the original game. The boundary of the platform is itself part of what must be defined.

Service continuity has several levels

The following is an analytical classification, not a technical diagnosis of every platform in the case studies.

Service state	What remains	What must not be inferred
Operated service	An operator maintains usable functions and admits eligible participants	Perpetual support or population growth
Reduced maintenance	Defined functions remain while updates, support or scope change	Feature parity with the earlier service
Residual session	An already-started client or session persists	New access, meaningful play or a viable community
Successor service	A different operator or arrangement supplies some continuity	Automatic transfer of accounts, promises or authority
Preservation or reconstruction	Software, records or a recreated experience survives	Preservation of every social relation, feature or right

There is no universal requirement to move through these states in order. A platform might close admissions before ending existing sessions, preserve an offline component, license a successor, or disappear without a usable migration path. The relevant unit is the function the person relied on, not simply whether a hostname responds.

An MMORPG illustrates why this matters. Authentication can work while a particular region has nobody available for a group activity. A town can look occupied while most visible characters are automated. An old client can launch while its saved character is inaccessible. Conversely, a small scheduled community can have excellent sessions despite low average concurrency. Availability, population and useful access are related but different outcomes.

3 Five MMORPG cases worth comparing

These are contrasting cases, not a ranking of the best games or a representative sample of all MMORPGs. The dates identify the evidence window. Historical figures are not presented as current population, and an operator's explanation is not an independent estimate of causality.

Case and dates	What persisted	Sustaining mechanism	Measured evidence	Main limit
EverQuest 2020 to 2026	Commercial game with continuing development	Paying established cohorts and maintenance [7] [8]	September 2020: 82,000 MAU; 66,000 members; US$11.5m bookings through 30 September [7]	Not current unique humans or profit
EVE Online 2026	Commercial shared world	Corporations, joint projects and continuing development [11]	No causal retention estimate in cited letter	Design intent is not measured effect
Old School RuneScape 2013 onward	Official restored and evolving branch	Demand for a preferred version and continuing use [13] [14]	449,351 supporting votes in 2013 [13]	Votes are not active players; progress restarted
WoW Classic Era 2021 to 2026	Official branch that does not advance into later expansions	Stay option and connected communities [16] [17] [19]	No Era population or profit figure used	Character copying was time limited [18]
City of Heroes and Homecoming 2012 to 2026	Closure, then a distinct community revival and license	Volunteers, donations and licensed stewardship [20] [22] [23]	September 2026: US$5,259.67 donations; US$5,200.18 recurring plus US$50 additional expenses [24]	Not uninterrupted service or an audited full cost

EverQuest shows the economic importance of established customers

The EG7 acquisition presentation defines members as customers who purchased monthly membership. Its financial measure is bookings, not profit. Across each of six Daybreak games, at least 65% of third-quarter 2020 bookings came from users with three or more years' tenure. This shows the commercial significance of established cohorts; it does not show that those people never paused, played elsewhere or returned after absence. [7]

EverQuest's September 2026 producer letter documents group-friendly quest changes, interface and trading improvements, and work on another expansion. The relevant persistence is therefore an actively maintained offering, not merely a machine that has escaped shutdown. [8]

Continuity can include internal migration. The 2024 Thornblade-to-Mischief merger preserved many character assets, while name conflicts and character-slot limits could affect individuals'

access. Official update notes confirmed completion on 17 July. The game could continue while a particular server identity disappeared. A merger should be evaluated by what each cohort actually retains, rather than described as either perfect continuity or total loss. [9] [10]

EVE makes relationships part of the continuing product

EVE's February 2026 directors' letter describes corporate projects, freelance work and collaboration as ways to move gradually from solo activity into shared purpose. It also documents continuing expansion work. This is unusually explicit evidence of the developer's intended social mechanism, but not a causal estimate of how many subscriptions it preserves. [11]

Its returning-player support policy adds a useful qualification: stored assets can remain in locations a returning person cannot access. Recovery routes and limited assistance exist, but not universal restoration of the former situation. Keeping an asset in a database differs from keeping it practically usable. [12]

A shared world can be valuable because friends, institutional memory and coordinated accomplishments are there. Calling all of this irrational attachment misses real future benefits. Conversely, preserving a character does not preserve a former alliance, role or convenient schedule. The social object is larger than the software record.

Old School RuneScape preserved preferred rules rather than old progress

Jagex's March 2013 announcement made a particularly clear distinction between enthusiasm and sustainability. After the supporting vote, it waived a proposed extra membership charge for at least six months, while explaining that future regular use would affect whether an additional fee became necessary. A vote from a sympathetic friend was not equivalent to continuing participation. This is an operator's explicit economic condition, not evidence that the eventual outcome had already been secured. [13]

The official support account says Old School RuneScape launched in 2013 from a 2007 backup, with characters starting afresh. Its progress and items are separate from RuneScape despite common account access. This was not an untouched 2007 service kept alive through uninterrupted sessions. [14]

The case weakens a pure accumulated-progress explanation: people can want an older ruleset enough to accept a fresh start. Its polling charter also illustrates bounded participation. Players can influence content, while the studio reserves decisions including pricing and specified integrity or balance changes. Community involvement is not unrestricted ownership of the service. [15]

WoW Classic Era separates staying from preserving every option forever

In 2021 Blizzard offered existing Classic characters a choice: advance into Burning Crusade Classic or remain in Classic Era. One branch was free to activate; activating the snapshot in both required the paid cloning service. Era used new realms retaining familiar names. Preservation of a version therefore did not require preservation of the original hardware or every underlying implementation. [16]

Blizzard connected groups of Era realms to support viable communities. Pooling reachable people is a different response to thin participation from adding simulated players. [17] Its January 2026 return promotion still listed Classic Era as an accessible version. [19]

The limits matter as much as the stay option. Blizzard retired cloning on 26 July 2022 and removed unactivated copies; a person who had never chosen would advance rather than retain the Era copy. An enduring branch did not preserve every historical option indefinitely. This is a concrete reason to document a transition's deadline, default and affected asset - not merely announce that the old version remains available. [18]

City of Heroes separates loyal demand from the authority to operate

The original service closed in late 2012. A contemporaneous campaign organizer's account establishes active efforts to save it, not independently verified claims about profitability or prospective buyers. The combination is enough for the counterexample: visible community commitment did not itself prevent closure. [20] [21]

Homecoming's own history dates its launch to April 2019. Its January 2024 announcement described a limited license from NCSOFT, continued free play and preservation of existing Homecoming characters. NCSOFT retained its intellectual property and the ability to require shutdown. That announcement did not establish restoration of every original 2012 account, permission for all other servers or perpetual operating authority. [22] [23]

The September 2026 cash figures in the matrix make the upkeep mechanism tangible. They are the operator's reports, not an audit; volunteer work is not valued in those cash totals. Donations and unpaid labor can sustain a different arrangement without demonstrating that the original studio could have supported the same world at the same cost. [24]

The lesson is neither that communities are powerless nor that devotion is sufficient. A community can become a steward when labor, funding, infrastructure and permission align. A revival may preserve much that matters while remaining a discontinuous and differently governed service.

4 Why people stay and what can make staying difficult to interpret

Real network value and switching costs are different

Farrell and Klemperer distinguish network effects, which connect a person's choice to other people's choices, from switching costs, which connect it to previous investments. Established communities can provide real benefits while making coordinated movement difficult. Neither network effects nor switching costs automatically establishes exploitation or inefficiency. [25]

For an MMORPG, the useful network is not simply the total account count. It is the people reachable in the relevant time zone, language, activity, skill range and role. A reliable organizer may matter more to one group than hundreds of unavailable accounts. This is an analytical observation, not a universal numerical threshold.

A 2007 observational study of five WoW servers associated guild survival with structural features including class balance and network density. Its models of individual advancement differed from its guild-survival models. The distinction matters: an organization persisting is not the same outcome as every member benefiting. The historical associations are not causal instructions for engineering a guild. [26]

A group can prefer continuity or fail to coordinate a move

Consider a hypothetical eight-person group. Each person values playing together at 10, prefers a new game by 3, and faces a migration cost of 1. Moving alone loses the group benefit; moving together improves each person's position by 2. Nobody moving is compatible with everyone preferring a coordinated move. These invented values illustrate a possibility, not real player preferences.

Research outside games supports taking that possibility seriously without diagnosing every community. Bursztyn and colleagues' incentivized studies of college students and social platforms found that accounting for effects on non-users could change the welfare interpretation relative to holding others' use fixed. Some active users preferred the platforms not to exist. This is evidence about those products, participants and study conditions, not a finding that MMORPG communities are generally traps. [27]

The opposite counterexample is equally important. People may understand their alternatives and prefer a familiar game's mechanics, culture or friends. Continued use after a genuinely workable exit becomes available can be a voluntary success. Retention alone cannot tell these stories apart.

Not every cost of leaving is a sunk cost

Past effort already spent cannot be recovered simply by playing more. But future access to a valued creation, character, relationship or reputation can be a real benefit worth preserving. Those two propositions are compatible. A person need not be irrational to care about losing work, and a high investment does not create an obligation to keep investing.

Some boundaries are explicitly documented. FFXIV's Home World Transfer rules preserve certain character items and records but do not transfer Free Company membership or housing; qualifying conditions and exceptions apply. This is partial portability, not complete immobility, and it does not establish a predatory motive. [28]

The useful question is what exactly must be rebuilt: skills, records, relationships, social status, paid access or technical setup. A compatibility constraint can be genuine. A confusing deadline or unnecessary obstacle can impose an avoidable burden. The two should not be assumed to have the same cause merely because both discourage departure.

5 What AI and automation can actually contribute

The categories below are a vocabulary for analysis, not allegations that any named operator uses all of them. They can coexist, but their effects must not be substituted for one another.

Category	What it does	What it does not establish
NPC teammates or opponents	Fill gameplay roles, often using conventional game logic	Human friendship, population or retained subscriptions
Automated player clients	Perform actions through player sessions	A human choosing to participate
Session persistence automation	Maintain a connection or alter timeout behavior	Fresh access or continued operator support
AI companions	Offer generated conversation or social interaction	A surviving human community or viable hosting
Predictive retention systems	Estimate future activity and tailor matching, offers or messages	Endorsed benefit or longer service life
Replacement servers or emulation	Supply infrastructure through another implementation or host	Continuation of the original operator's service
Offline preservation	Keep a usable local component or record	The original live economy and social world

Supported NPC play is a genuine feature with a narrower claim

FFXIV's Duty Support manual documents NPC parties for eligible progression dungeons, removing the need to queue with other players for those activities. This establishes a supported way to complete content with fewer humans. It does not measure a retention effect or show an avoided shutdown. [29]

Blizzard's 2024 Follower Dungeons announcement similarly describes NPCs filling missing roles in the announced Normal Dragonflight dungeons. Its stated uses include learning and exploring at one's own pace. It is not evidence that WoW had become commercially unviable without simulated players. [30]

These features can reduce scheduling difficulty, improve access or let someone practice privately. They need not pretend that the companions are human. They can also change the opportunities for meeting strangers. Which effect dominates requires evidence about the actual activity and people, not a conclusion drawn from the presence of NPCs.

AI companionship is a separate proposition. A generative or social agent may offer interaction that a person wants, but no case verified for this reference establishes that AI companions preserved official MMORPG hosting or replaced a continuing human community. A party-filling NPC should not be silently promoted into evidence for that broader claim.

Retention prediction is not the same as a bot playing the game

The 2017 EOMM paper proposed engagement-optimized matchmaking and evaluated it in simulation using real data from an unnamed EA game. It establishes research into matching based on predicted engagement, not confirmed deployment in a named title or a causal increase in server lifetime. A model's objective and a demonstrated user outcome are different facts. [31]

Predictive systems can in principle reduce frustrating mismatches, but an increase in future play does not by itself show that people endorse the resulting experience. Meaningful assessment would distinguish voluntary benefit, misleading population signals, unwanted pressure and the operational effect. No new tracking or experiment is authorized by naming these questions.

Bots can survive the shutdown without preventing it

Knockout City is not an MMORPG, but it is an unusually useful contrast. Velan attributed its planned closure partly to difficulty retaining enough players for sustainability and the difficulty of making major changes while supporting the live game. That is the studio's explanation, not an independently isolated causal estimate. [32]

The studio subsequently confirmed that official servers went offline on 6 June 2023 and released a privately hosted edition. Its product page specifies online, LAN and solo bot play. Bot-supported gameplay thus survived through a different delivery arrangement; the original official service did not. [33] [34]

A system can preserve the activity, reduce its dependence on a large simultaneous population, or create a route to independent hosting. Those are valuable possibilities. None should be described as proof that AI kept the original servers open.

6 How to compare persistence without manufacturing a retention story

A useful comparison starts with the outcome and denominator. The cases above do not provide a common migration rate. Votes, monthly activity, paid memberships, bookings and donations should not appear on one population axis. Their differences are substantive, not formatting problems.

For later documentary work, a compact evidence record would separate these questions:

- **Service:** Which functions remain available, to which eligible users, during which dates? Separate new admission, existing sessions, matchmaking, saved records and local use.
- **Participation:** Does the figure count people, accounts, characters, clients, subscriptions or NPCs? Is it a point-in-time count, peak, monthly total or cumulative registration count?
- **Return:** What starting cohort and observation interval define retention? Are reactivation, continuous activity and payment renewal separated? Is activity elsewhere known or simply unobserved?
- **Useful access:** Can a person actually complete the relevant activity with reachable partners, or use a preserved asset? Low global population need not mean low value for a scheduled group.
- **Sustainability:** What income, donated labor, operating costs, rights and dependencies support the specific arrangement? Revenue is not profit, and cash expenses are not the full value of unpaid work.

- **Agency:** Can people pause, decline, export, move together or leave separately without misleading information or avoidable loss? More time connected is not a substitute for an endorsed outcome.

These are questions for interpreting available evidence, not a proposal to begin collecting personal data. Unknowns should remain unknown. A small project does not need invasive measurement merely because a large platform publishes a dashboard.

The causal claim that AI kept a platform alive would need several links: an identified deployed system; a demonstrated effect on meaningful human activity; evidence that this change affected the operator's ability or decision to maintain the service; and a credible account of what would otherwise have happened. New content, price changes, consolidation, alternative funding or a new operator are competing explanations. A surviving service and an AI feature appearing in the same period do not establish that chain.

A weaker claim can still be useful. A manual can establish that NPC-supported play exists. A financial report can establish dated commercial dependence on established cohorts. An operator letter can establish a maintenance policy. The discipline is to keep each finding at the level its evidence supports.

7 Planning for closure without erasing the promise

Preserve the benefit rather than an undefined label

The earlier grandfathering analysis distinguished an entitlement from immunity for its delivery method. This distinction becomes especially important for persistent platforms. Keeping a character, a price, a version, a community and a particular server are five different promises. Preserving one does not establish preservation of the others.

A hypothetical continuity record should identify the protected cohort and benefit, the responsible operator, the actual duration and conditions, and the dependencies on which delivery rests. It should distinguish a review date from an automatic termination date. A new maintenance problem is not authority to invent a forfeiture condition after people relied on an offer. Equally, an old promise should not be expanded into perpetual hosting if that was never promised.

Where the old method cannot continue, compare the actual alternatives: a maintained legacy branch, consolidation, reduced functionality, readable records, a usable export, an authorized successor or an offline component. These are not interchangeable remedies. A replacement that preserves the mechanics can still lose friendships, moderation arrangements, history or a person's prior access. A safe and authorized transition should make those losses visible rather than call every replacement seamless.

Export is not the same as migration

Mastodon's documented process illustrates the distinction outside gaming. Followers can move to a new account; other lists use export and import. Posts and media can be archived but are not imported into the new account through the documented migration feature. A downloadable archive, restored functionality and continuity of relationships are separate capabilities. [35]

Its Server Covenant offers a different continuity measure: servers in the official picker commit to at least three months' advance shutdown warning, alongside backup and emergency-access requirements. That is a stated obligation of participating listed servers, not a universal guarantee for every instance or proof that every exit succeeds. [36]

For any proposed transition, notice should explain what ends, what remains, what action is optional or necessary, and what deadlines and defaults apply. Group movement should preserve each person's choice; a majority's wish to relocate does not authorize transferring everyone else's personal information. A remaining participant's attachment deserves consideration, but does not itself establish an unlimited veto over maintainers, other users or infrastructure. Specific legal obligations require their own review; this reference does not determine them.

8 What this means for Blackwish

The supplied baseline is an offline-first creative prototype, not an established MMORPG or hosted social platform. Nothing here establishes existing multiplayer hosting, AI companions, retention targeting, population telemetry or account migration in Blackwish. The earlier advertising reports' ratification does not extend to this research or authorize any resulting implementation.

The strongest transferable questions concern continuity of the person's work:

1. **Can a complete useful task finish?** A person who makes the desired object and closes the application may have succeeded. Unattended runtime would add no corresponding evidence of value.
2. **What remains usable without the original operator?** Saving, reopening, export, dependency availability and compatibility need separate evidence. Offline-first is an intended direction, not proof that every installation or future environment is independent.
3. **What would make a voluntary return worthwhile?** Better creative choices, understandable revisions and dependable access are possible reasons. Their presence and benefit must be demonstrated rather than inferred from the project's purpose.
4. **What earlier commitments must survive a change?** Preserve the original wording, cohort and evidence. Reviewing an implementation does not silently cancel a benefit or make earlier legitimate use wrongful.
5. **How can the person leave with dignity?** A usable result, understandable limits and freedom from compulsory sharing can matter more than a high return frequency. Any new export or migration claim must match the actual capability.

These are private text and specification checks. They do not add features, define public terms, initiate tracking or instruct anyone to operate bots. If future online functionality is proposed, its

purpose, maintenance resources, permissions, population claims and closure path would need a separate review and the user's explicit manual ratification.

A narrowly bounded hypothetical illustrates the goal. Suppose a creator uses a future build once, saves a complete result, verifies it can be reopened, and never returns because the task is done. A session-retention objective might call this failure. A durable-access objective would ask whether the person obtained what they wanted and retained it. The example is not a finding about the current build; it shows why platform longevity should serve the activity rather than become its own justification.

9 Three distinct Zen text review rounds

POINT, BRIDGE, PATH and SHADOW are used here as an **operational interpretation for manuscript review**, not verbatim Blackwish canon. POINT identifies the claim or objective; BRIDGE checks evidence and authority; PATH examines consequences, alternatives and termination; SHADOW examines limits, counterexamples and protected losses. These are bounded text checks, not empirical safety certification, human experiments, deployment approval or manual ratification.

Round one evidence and the meaning of persistence

POINT: Explain why a platform persists without turning every surviving connection into a successful service or every old account into a continuously retained person.

BRIDGE: Match the unit of evidence to the claim. Operator notices concern service policy; participant accounts concern their experience; company metrics concern specified historical measures; models and simulations have their own scope.

PATH: Separate admission, useful functions, client state and maintenance. Separate a cohort's tenure from continuous use, renewal, migration and multihoming. Preserve the dates and denominators in the comparison rather than invent a common retention score.

SHADOW: The bounded counterexample is an unattended client that remains present while no human can complete the intended activity. It defeats the broad inference that remaining connected means the community survived. The narrower conclusion preserves the connection evidence without pretending it establishes more. No additional architectural conclusion follows without new evidence.

Round two agency and the reasons people remain

POINT: Recognize genuine affection, useful relationships and creative investment without treating all staying as either healthy preference or captivity.

BRIDGE: Distinguish network benefits, switching burdens, nonportable records and social obligations. Continued activity is not direct evidence of satisfaction; frustration with a transition is not direct evidence of unlawful conduct or predatory intent.

PATH: Make both staying and leaving intelligible options. An NPC that openly helps complete an activity differs from an agent misrepresented as a human friend. Coordinated migration can be a legitimate success, while individuals remain free to decline it.

SHADOW: The bounded counterexample is a well-informed group that has a workable exit and freely chooses its old world. It defeats a universal lock-in diagnosis. Conversely, the hypothetical group unable to coordinate a preferred move defeats a universal satisfaction inference. The surviving principle is to preserve choice and seek the relevant evidence rather than read motives from duration.

Round three lifecycle commitments and protected loss

POINT: Preserve the specific benefit people relied on through maintenance, transition or a clearly described end, without making unsupported promises of permanence.

BRIDGE: Identify the responsible party, actual terms, resources, dependencies and authority. A successor needs its own basis for operation. An analytical proposal does not acquire implementation authority through this document.

PATH: Compare preserved and lost functions for each cohort; protect originals and relevant data-use promises; make deadlines, defaults, export limits and remedies explicit. Replacing the delivery method is not automatically fulfillment or breach.

SHADOW: The bounded counterexample is an old method that can no longer be maintained safely or with the required permission. Freezing it cannot be a universal rule. But that limitation does not erase reliance or justify an unrelated withdrawal. The surviving principle is benefit-preserving adaptation where feasible, and specific, authorized, humane closure where it is not.

These rounds stop at the distinctions they can establish from documents and hypothetical cases. Reopen an affected conclusion when its evidence, platform, promise or proposed implementation changes materially. Repeating the same text review would not resolve an unknown population, prove consent or certify readiness.

Conclusion

People can help keep an online world valuable through friendship, shared projects, preferred rules and continuing financial support. Operators can preserve access through maintenance, pooling populations, supported NPC play or a different stewardship arrangement. Those mechanisms sometimes reinforce one another, but none creates a general rule that the last user keeps the servers alive.

The most useful question is not simply why people fail to leave. It is **what remains worth having, what makes it possible to keep providing it, and what the person can preserve if they choose to go**. For Blackwish, that points toward demonstrable usefulness, durable access and honest lifecycle commitments - not an assumption that greater dependence or longer connection time is progress.

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